



“The destiny of our homeland hinges on the decisive battle in the Southern Seas, where I shall fall like a blossom from a radiant cherry tree.”

JAPANESE FLYING OFFICER

WRITING ON THE EVE OF A KAMIKAZE MISSION

PILOTED BOMB

Its nose packed with explosives, the Japanese Ohka22 piloted bomb was carried into action by a bomber aircraft. After its release, the kamikaze pilot ignited rockets and guided the bomb to its target.



AIR WAR AT SEA

AIRCRAFT WERE AS CRUCIAL IN NAVAL WARFARE AS IN THE WAR ON LAND, ESPECIALLY IN THE PACIFIC WHERE CARRIER FORCES BATTLED AT LONG RANGE

ON THE EVENING OF MAY 7, 1942, a formation of aircraft with their landing lights on approached the US Navy carriers *Yorktown* and *Lexington* as they steamed through the Coral Sea in the South Pacific. When one of the carriers' destroyer escorts opened fire on the planes, a sharp message was radioed to its captain telling him to stop shooting at friendly aircraft. The destroyer's skipper snapped back that he knew Japanese planes when he saw them. Sure enough, they were Japanese carrier aircraft that had become confused

in the failing light and mistaken the American ships for their own. As every gun in the US fleet opened up, the Japanese pilots switched off their lights and scattered into the darkness. For the next half hour, American radio operators could hear their Japanese opposite numbers talking their aircraft down somewhere out in the dark ocean.

This kind of incident was to be expected as two navies invented a new way of making war. The Japanese and American forces had been feeling blindly for one another for days, with aerial reconnaissance inhibited by much low cloud. The Japanese carriers *Zuikaku* and *Shokaku* were veterans of the attack on the US naval base at Pearl Harbor (see page 222), but the American carrier aircraft had had their first experience of war only earlier that same day, when *Devastator* torpedo-bombers and *Dauntless* dive-bombers sank the Japanese light carrier *Shoho* – an occasion celebrated by pilot Bob Dixon, who led the attack, with the pithy message: “Scratch one flattop.”

